Vijayarama Rao, the CBI director,' he said. He shook hands with me before making all of his colleagues introduce themselves to me.

Many of them had introduced themselves to me earlier, now they did it again, coming forward one by one, inspector general M L Sharma, deputy inspector general P M Nair, who later became a consultant for TIFR; Ashok Kumar, then an SP who later became the Tamil Nadu DGP; R S Dhankar, who was later examined as a witness in my compensation case against the Kerala government; Saxena, P C Sharma, who later became NHRC member … Having endured IB's nameless agents of torture for four days, these investigators with real names came as a refreshing change, even a ray of hope that I would finally be heard.

'We will be happy if you tell us the truth,' Vijayarama Rao said.

I felt relieved with his manners, but his next sentence wasn't so soothing.

'Do you think your colleague Sasikumaran might have sold some drawings to foreigners?'

It was an old question, to which I had explained repeatedly to different people there is no way rocket technology can be transferred through drawings. But this time the question indicated a couple of things: one, Rao had scant respect for Sasi who he was convinced had met the Maldivian women; two, he realised that I had never met those Maldivian women.

Now I too had reasons to hate Sasi who must have met the women and hence landed ISRO in trouble.

My answer to the question, however, was a quick 'no'.

I made a request. 'Instead of this session beginning with your questions, shall I first explain how the Indian Space Research Organisation works?' I said.

'Please do,' said Rao.

I was ready to repeat what I did with the first set of CBI investigators.

I asked for a pen and sheets of paper. When they came, I assumed the air of a professor and started drawing the organisational chart of ISRO. Running the CBI officials through the hierarchy of Indian space programme, I showed them where I stood—not so high on the seniority list,